Who Rules Britain? Sovereignty, Crown and People

English · Terminale · tronc commun B2, C1 tasks · spécialité LLCER towards C1 · 14 lessons of 55 minutes

Road map

Lessons of 55 minutes, timed for 52 minutes. 14 lessons: eight sessions (session 6 in two lessons), the mid-sequence assessment, a revision workshop, the written test (two lessons or one 2-hour slot) and the final task.

1. Lesson 1 · A constitution nobody can print 52 min

   Find where British rules are written, read Dicey on parliamentary sovereignty and debate a written constitution.

   - 7 min · Warm-up: where are the rules of France written, and where are the rules of the UK?
   - 15 min · Reading Dicey: the two halves of the principle; exercise 1.1
   - 6 min · Concept: convention (Royal Assent, 1708)
   - 14 min · Mini-debate: a written constitution for the UK?
   - 5 min · Exercise 1.2: the language of Dicey
   - 5 min · Written record and homework
   - **Written record.** Parliamentary sovereignty (Dicey, 1885): Parliament can make or unmake any law, and no person or body can override it. Strength: flexibility. Danger: an "elective dictatorship" (Lord Hailsham, 1976).
   - **Participation.** Everyone speaks at least once: each student names one place where British rules are written in the warm-up, or speaks once from the floor in the mini-debate.
   - **Homework for next lesson.** 120 words: "The British constitution is a strength, not a weakness." Agree or disagree, with one example. Start your flashcards: five cards (sovereignty, convention, to override, statute, elective dictatorship).

   Stopping point. End of lesson 1. Next time: Magna Carta, myth and law.

   Emergency exit · 8 min. If time runs short, stop at the reading of Dicey (the mini-debate becomes a quick round). In the last 8 minutes: dictate the written record (Parliamentary sovereignty (Dicey, 1885): Parliament can make or unmake any law, and no person or body can override it. Strength: flexibility. Danger: an "elective dictatorship" (Lord Hailsham, 1976)); a quick round of the class, one source of British rules each, so that everyone has spoken at least once; write the homework on the board (120 words: "The British constitution is a strength, not a weakness." Agree or disagree, with one example. Start your flashcards: five cards (sovereignty, convention, to override, statute, elective dictatorship)).

2. Lesson 2 · Magna Carta, 1215: myth and law 52 min

   Read chapter 29 as a legal text, separate myth from history with Coke, and mediate the clause into French.

   - 5 min · Recap: Dicey in two sentences
   - 12 min · Close reading of chapter 29; exercise 2.1
   - 10 min · Myth versus history, and Coke in 1628; exercise 2.2
   - 12 min · Mediation into French (C1 option) or exercise 2.3 (B2)
   - 8 min · Pooling: what is Magna Carta used to justify?

- 5 min · Written record and homework
- **Written record.** Chapter 29 sets out due process: the king is under "the law of the land". It protected free men, not everyone; its prestige was built later (Coke, 1628; the American colonies).
- **Participation.** Everyone speaks at least once: each student reads out one answer to exercise 2.2 (myth or history?) and justifies it.
- **Homework for next lesson.** Find one modern speech or article that quotes Magna Carta. What is it used to justify? Add four cards to your pack.

Stopping point. End of lesson 2. Next time: 1689.

Emergency exit · 8 min. If time runs short, stop at the mediation (it becomes homework). In the last 8 minutes: dictate the written record (Chapter 29 sets out due process: the king is under "the law of the land". It protected free men, not everyone; its prestige was built later (Coke, 1628; the American colonies)); a quick round of the class, one myth-or-history answer each, so that everyone has spoken at least once; write the homework on the board (Find one modern speech or article that quotes Magna Carta. What is it used to justify? Add four cards to your pack).

3. Lesson 3 · 1689: Parliament takes control 52 min

   Analyse how the Bill of Rights presents a revolution as a restoration, and why article 9 still matters.

   - 5 min · Recap: one use of Magna Carta found at home
   - 8 min · Context and the preamble: who is blamed?
   - 14 min · Analysis: "pretended" power and article 9; exercise 3.1
   - 10 min · Exercise 3.2: article 9 today
   - 10 min · 1689 and 1789: exercise 3.3, oral comparison
   - 5 min · Written record and homework
   - **Written record.** "Pretended" power: Parliament presents change as the restoration of old rights, which gives it legitimacy. Article 9: parliamentary privilege, free speech in Parliament that no court can question.
   - **Participation.** Everyone speaks at least once: each student gives one line of the 1689 and 1789 comparison.
   - **Homework for next lesson.** Compare 1689 with 1789 in France in 100 words: same goal, different method? Add four cards.

   Stopping point. End of lesson 3. Next time: the dignified Crown.

   Emergency exit · 8 min. If time runs short, stop at exercise 3.2 (exercise 3.3 becomes the homework plan). In the last 8 minutes: dictate the written record ("Pretended" power: Parliament presents change as the restoration of old rights, which gives it legitimacy. Article 9: parliamentary privilege, free speech in Parliament that no court can question); a quick round of the class, one comparison point each, so that everyone has spoken at least once; write the homework on the board (Compare 1689 with 1789 in France in 100 words: same goal, different method? Add four cards).

4. Lesson 4 · The dignified Crown 52 min

   Test Bagehot's dignified and efficient parts against today's monarchy and argue a paradox.

   - 5 min · Recap: 1689 in one sentence

- 10 min · Reading Bagehot
- 10 min · Sort, harder version; exercise 4.1
- 10 min · Discussion: compliment or criticism? Exercise 4.2
- 12 min · Speaking task: 2 minutes on the paradox, in pairs, then three students for the class
- 5 min · Written record and homework
- **Written record.** Bagehot (1867): dignified parts win reverence, efficient parts govern. The sovereign's three rights: to be consulted, to encourage, to warn.
- **Participation.** Everyone speaks at least once: each student defends or attacks the paradox for at least 30 seconds to a partner, and three students speak to the class.
- **Homework for next lesson.** Next lesson: mid-sequence assessment. Watch extracts of the most recent King's Speech on the UK Parliament website: who wrote it, and which three bills are announced? Revise sessions 1 to 4 with your flashcards.

Stopping point. End of lesson 4. Next time: the mid-sequence assessment.

Emergency exit · 8 min. If time runs short, stop at the discussion (the speaking task is done in pairs only). In the last 8 minutes: dictate the written record (Bagehot (1867): dignified parts win reverence, efficient parts govern. The sovereign's three rights: to be consulted, to encourage, to warn); a quick round of the class, one sentence on the paradox each, so that everyone has spoken at least once; write the homework on the board (Next lesson: mid-sequence assessment. Watch extracts of the most recent King's Speech on the UK Parliament website: who wrote it, and which three bills are announced? Revise sessions 1 to 4 with your flashcards).

5. Lesson 5 · Mid-sequence assessment 52 min

   Check that students can read an authentic source and argue, before the harder sessions.

   - 3 min · Instructions, and a quick round: one key word each
   - 22 min · Part A: reading an unseen source (/10)
   - 22 min · Part B: short argument, 150 to 180 words (/10)
   - 5 min · Self-correction grid
   - **Written record.** The self-correction grid, filled in and kept in the notebook.
   - **Participation.** Everyone speaks at least once: in the opening round, each student says one key word of sessions 1 to 4 (sovereignty, convention, due process, privilege, dignified...).
   - **Homework for next lesson.** Bring your flashcards and your King's Speech notes. Read the 2016 figures in the table of session 5.

   Stopping point. End of lesson 5. Next time: the Brexit paradox.

   Emergency exit · 8 min. If time runs short: Part B is reduced to 120 words and the self-correction grid is filled in at home. The opening round of key words is kept, so everyone has spoken; the homework is written on the board.

6. Lesson 6 · Sovereignty and the people: the Brexit paradox 52 min

   Explain who is sovereign when Parliament and the people disagree, and plan an argument on referendums.

   - 5 min · Recap: the mid-sequence assessment, two points to remember
   - 8 min · The data, read as evidence
   - 12 min · Analysis: control by whom, from whom? Exercise 5.1

- 7 min · The results by nation: what they say about the Union
- 12 min · Writing (B2): plan and introduction of 180 words
- 8 min · Exercise 5.2: hedging, then written record and homework
- **Written record.** The Brexit paradox: a vote to restore the sovereignty of Parliament was a vote of the people that Parliament felt obliged to follow.
- **Participation.** Everyone speaks at least once: each student reads out their hedged sentence (exercise 5.2) or their introduction.
- **Homework for next lesson.** Finish the 180 words: "Referendums strengthen democracy." Discuss. Read the Burke quotation in the sources and summarise it in one sentence.

Stopping point. End of lesson 6. Next time: the courts and the 2019 prorogation.

Emergency exit · 8 min. If time runs short, stop at the analysis (the writing becomes homework). In the last 8 minutes: dictate the written record (The Brexit paradox: a vote to restore the sovereignty of Parliament was a vote of the people that Parliament felt obliged to follow); a quick round of the class, one hedged sentence each, so that everyone has spoken at least once; write the homework on the board (Finish the 180 words: "Referendums strengthen democracy." Discuss. Read the Burke quotation in the sources and summarise it in one sentence).

7. Lesson 7 · Courts versus government (1): the facts and the judgment 52 min

   Reconstruct the 2019 prorogation case and read the Court's conclusion.

   - 5 min · Recap: Burke in one sentence
   - 10 min · Facts and timeline; exercise 6.1
   - 12 min · Reading the judgment; exercise 6.2
   - 10 min · Discussion: protecting Parliament or entering politics?
   - 10 min · Groups formed for the mock hearing; roles and arguments shared out
   - 5 min · Written record and homework
   - **Written record.** R (Miller) v The Prime Minister; Cherry [2019] UKSC 41: the advice to prorogue was unlawful because it frustrated Parliament without reasonable justification; the prorogation was void.
   - **Participation.** Everyone speaks at least once: each student says one sentence in the discussion: courts protecting Parliament, or courts entering politics.
   - **Homework for next lesson.** Prepare your part of the mock hearing: your argument in three sentences, with one link to Dicey or to article 9. Add four cards.

   Stopping point. End of lesson 7. Next time: the mock hearing.

   Emergency exit · 8 min. If time runs short, stop at the discussion. In the last 8 minutes: dictate the written record (R (Miller) v The Prime Minister; Cherry [2019] UKSC 41: the advice to prorogue was unlawful because it frustrated Parliament without reasonable justification; the prorogation was void); a quick round of the class, one position sentence each, so that everyone has spoken at least once; write the homework on the board (Prepare your part of the mock hearing: your argument in three sentences, with one link to Dicey or to article 9. Add four cards).

8. Lesson 8 · Courts versus government (2): the mock hearing 52 min

   Argue a case as counsel or judge and deliver a reasoned ruling.

- 5 min · Set-up of the courtroom, recap of the roles
- 15 min · Groups finalise their arguments; exercise 6.3 for the judges
- 6 min · Hearing: counsel for the government, then for the claimants (3 minutes each)
- 8 min · The judges deliberate; counsel prepare one reply each
- 5 min · The ruling delivered
- 8 min · Debrief: what the Supreme Court really said; written record
- 5 min · Homework
- **Written record.** Our ruling in three sentences, compared with the Court's: it decided Parliament's role, not the date of Brexit.
- **Participation.** Everyone speaks at least once: each member of a group says one argument or one reason of the ruling in the hearing.
- **Homework for next lesson.** 150 words: "The judges did their job." Agree or disagree.

Stopping point. End of lesson 8. Next time: the Lords and the Union.

Emergency exit · 8 min. If time runs short, stop at the hearing (the judges give a short oral ruling). In the last 8 minutes: dictate the written record (Our ruling in three sentences, compared with the Court's: it decided Parliament's role, not the date of Brexit); a quick round of the class, one argument each, so that everyone has spoken at least once; write the homework on the board (150 words: "The judges did their job." Agree or disagree).

9. Lesson 9 · An unelected chamber and a disunited kingdom? 52 min

   Discuss the legitimacy of an appointed chamber and the Scottish claim to a second referendum.

   - 5 min · Recap: the 2019 ruling in one sentence
   - 8 min · The Lords: from hereditary to appointed; exercise 7.2
   - 8 min · The Union: devolution, 2014 and the 2022 ruling
   - 10 min · Reading: "Take back control" and the Scottish argument; exercise 7.1
   - 15 min · Debate: a second independence referendum?
   - 6 min · Written record and homework
   - **Written record.** Same logic, opposite conclusion: if the people are sovereign, Scotland can claim a vote; legally, Westminster is sovereign, so the Supreme Court refused in 2022.
   - **Participation.** Everyone speaks at least once: each student speaks once in the debate (as a speaker or from the floor).
   - **Homework for next lesson.** Prepare a 1-minute statement as a Scottish, Welsh, Northern Irish or English MP. Add four cards.

   Stopping point. End of lesson 9. Next time: votes at sixteen.

   Emergency exit · 8 min. If time runs short, stop at the reading (the debate is kept to one round). In the last 8 minutes: dictate the written record (Same logic, opposite conclusion: if the people are sovereign, Scotland can claim a vote; legally, Westminster is sovereign, so the Supreme Court refused in 2022); a quick round of the class, one argument each, so that everyone has spoken at least once; write the homework on the board (Prepare a 1-minute statement as a Scottish, Welsh, Northern Irish or English MP. Add four cards).

10. Lesson 10 · Votes at 16: a bill in progress 52 min

Read a parliamentary briefing, weigh the evidence on votes at sixteen and choose the final task.

- 5 min · Recap: two 1-minute MP statements
- 12 min · Reading the House of Commons Library briefing; exercise 8.1
- 15 min · Debate: are you ready? Every speaker uses one figure
- 5 min · Exercise 8.2: weighing evidence
- 10 min · Briefing for the final task: role and format
- 5 min · Written record and homework
- **Written record.** Two arguments for and two against votes at sixteen, each with one figure or fact, and the stage of the bill on the day of the lesson.
- **Participation.** Everyone speaks at least once: each student gives one argument with a figure, or states their final task choice.
- **Homework for next lesson.** Choose your final task and write its plan. Finish your flashcard pack (20 cards or more).

Stopping point. End of lesson 10. Next time: revision and final task workshop.

Emergency exit · 8 min. If time runs short, stop at the debate. In the last 8 minutes: dictate the written record (Two arguments for and two against votes at sixteen, each with one figure or fact, and the stage of the bill on the day of the lesson); a quick round of the class, one argument or one choice each, so that everyone has spoken at least once; write the homework on the board (Choose your final task and write its plan. Finish your flashcard pack (20 cards or more)).

11. Lesson 11 · Revision and final task workshop 52 min

    Revise with the flashcards, train the language for argument and plan the final task.

    - 5 min · Recap: one primary source each
    - 12 min · Flashcards in pairs, three boxes
    - 10 min · Building your vocabulary: exercises L.1 and L.2
    - 20 min · Planning the final task: three sources, one objection, checklist
    - 5 min · Written record and homework
    - **Written record.** My plan, my three primary sources and the objection I will answer.
    - **Participation.** Everyone speaks at least once: each student names the three primary sources they will use.
    - **Homework for next lesson.** Revise for the written test (documents of sessions 6 and 8, the essay method). Rehearse your speech or draft your op-ed or ruling.

    Stopping point. End of lesson 11. Next time: the written test.

    Emergency exit · 8 min. If time runs short, stop at the flashcards. In the last 8 minutes: dictate the written record (My plan, my three primary sources and the objection I will answer); a quick round of the class, one primary source each, so that everyone has spoken at least once; write the homework on the board (Revise for the written test (documents of sessions 6 and 8, the essay method). Rehearse your speech or draft your op-ed or ruling).

12. Lesson 12 · Summative written test (1): comprehension and mediation 52 min

Read two unseen sources and mediate into French. Best done in one 2-hour exam slot with lesson 13; otherwise over two lessons.

- 2 min · Instructions
- 3 min · Opening round: one key word each
- 15 min · Question 1: Document A (/5)
- 15 min · Question 2: Document B (/5)
- 17 min · Question 3: mediation in French (/4)
- **Written record.** The answers to questions 1 to 3, handed in.
- **Participation.** Everyone speaks at least once: in the opening round, each student says one key word they will use in the test.
- **Homework for next lesson.** Reread the essay method (introduction, two parts, conclusion) and your notes on Brexit, 2019, Scotland and votes at 16.

Stopping point. End of lesson 12: papers collected. Next time: the essay.

Emergency exit · 8 min. If time runs short: question 3 is reduced to 70 words. The opening round is kept, so everyone has spoken; papers are collected; the homework is written on the board.

13. Lesson 13 · Summative written test (2): the essay 52 min

Write an argued essay on sovereignty in theory and in practice.

- 3 min · Opening round: each student says their thesis in one sentence
- 5 min · Plan on the draft sheet
- 40 min · Question 4: essay, 250 to 300 words (/6)
- 4 min · Self-correction grid
- **Written record.** The essay, with the self-correction grid stapled to it.
- **Participation.** Everyone speaks at least once: in the opening round, each student says their thesis in one sentence.
- **Homework for next lesson.** Final rehearsal of the speech or ruling; op-eds handed in at the start of the next lesson.

Stopping point. End of lesson 13. Next time: the Commons sits (final task).

Emergency exit · 8 min. If time runs short: the plan is skipped and the essay is limited to 220 words; the self-correction grid is filled in at home. The opening round is kept; the homework is written on the board.

14. Lesson 14 · Final task: the Commons sits 52 min

Deliver the speeches and rulings, hand in the op-eds and assess with the grid.

- 4 min · Set-up: order of speakers, op-eds collected, peer grids handed out
- 42 min · Speeches in the Commons (4 minutes + 2 minutes of questions) and C1 rulings presented
- 6 min · Written record: self-assessment with the grid
- **Written record.** My strength and one point to improve, from the grid.
- **Participation.** Everyone speaks at least once: speakers deliver their speech or ruling; op-ed writers each ask one question during the questions.

- **Homework for next lesson.** Read the corrected grids. With more than seven speakers, the remaining speeches open the next lessons, two per lesson.

Stopping point. End of the sequence.

Emergency exit · 8 min. If time runs short: each remaining speaker gives the first minute of their speech and answers one question; the rest open the next lessons. The grid is filled in at home; the homework is written on the board.

Building on The King Reigns

This sequence is the advanced Terminale version of The King Reigns, Parliament Rules (Première and Terminale, B1+ towards B2). It can be taught on its own, but it never repeats the work done there. When a document has already been studied in The King Reigns, it comes back here as a starting point, with a new question and a new task. A box **"You already know"** opens each session.

Already studied in The King Reigns	What is new here
Who can do what: the King, the Prime Minister, Parliament (session 1)	Dicey's theory of parliamentary sovereignty and the debate on a written constitution (session 1)
Magna Carta, chapter 29, rewritten in today's English; the story of 1215; the Fifth Amendment and 1948 (sessions 2 and 3)	Chapter 29 read as a legal text; myth versus history; Coke in 1628; mediation into French (session 2)
The Bill of Rights: spelling game and what the King can no longer do (session 4)	The preamble, the word "pretended", article 9 and parliamentary privilege today; 1689 and 1789 (session 3)
Bagehot: two columns, dignified and efficient; Royal Assent; the Government writes the King's Speech (session 5)	Bagehot's own words; a harder sort with justification; the paradox of a "dignified" Crown; an unseen Bagehot text in the mid-sequence assessment (session 4)
The path of a bill and the stages of the Hereditary Peers Act 2026 (session 6)	The legitimacy of an appointed chamber (session 7)
The 2016 figures, the map of the four nations, the 2014 referendum, a first debate on votes at sixteen (session 8)	The Brexit paradox of sovereignty (session 5); the 2019 prorogation case (session 6); the 2022 Supreme Court ruling on a Scottish referendum (session 7); the Commons Library briefing and evidence-based debate (session 8)
Final task: a 3-minute speech as a new MP, or a 250 to 300-word op-ed on Magna Carta	Final task: a speech in the Commons with 2 minutes of questions, a 350 to 400-word op-ed on a written constitution, or a mock Supreme Court ruling; plus a mid-sequence assessment and a 2-hour written test
Paintings: Monet, Normand, Turner (with photographs of Westminster and Runnymede)	Different images: Dicey, the 1215 manuscript, Wale's engraving of 1689, Bagehot, the Supreme Court, Holyrood, a polling station

Students who did not follow The King Reigns can read its session pages as background: each "You already know" box gives the link.

Framework

Problem

Is the United Kingdom governed by its King, its Parliament, its courts or its people? And can a country with no single written constitution protect democracy?

Curriculum

Terminale, theme 6 « The United Kingdom and its nations » (a Kingdom still united?), with links to the political speech topic and to citizenship. This is the frame used in The King Reigns, Parliament Rules.

Levels

Tronc commun, Terminale: **B2** (the core tasks). Spécialité LLCER anglais: **towards C1** (the C1 extensions). In Première, the tronc commun target is B1+ towards B2: use The King Reigns.

Why this version is harder

- Every session starts from an **unadapted primary source**: a charter, a statute, a court judgment, a speech or a parliamentary briefing.
- Students compare **competing theories** (Dicey and Bagehot) and test them against **real crises**: Brexit, prorogation in 2019, Scottish independence.
- The tasks are **argumentative**: rebuttal, mediation of a source into French, a mock Supreme Court ruling, a debate in the Commons.
- The vocabulary is the vocabulary of constitutional debate: sovereignty, convention, accountability, legitimacy, devolution, mandate.

Assessed outcomes

Skill	B2 core	C1 extension
Reading	Identify the claim, the evidence and the tone of an authentic text.	Explain implicit assumptions and how the text could be used by opposing sides.
Speaking	Defend a position for 3 minutes with two arguments and one example.	React to an objection without notes; concede, then counter.
Writing	An organised argumentative text of 250 to 300 words.	Nuanced conclusion; hedging; register appropriate to an op-ed.
Mediation	Summarise an English source in French for a given reader.	Select and reframe information for a specific purpose.

Assessment plan

- Mid-sequence assessment after session 4 (lesson 5): /20, coefficient 1.
- Summative written test, 2 hours (lessons 12 and 13): /20, coefficient 2.
- Final task (lesson 14): /20, coefficient 2.

The eight sessions

Each session below is one 52-minute lesson, except session 6, which takes two lessons (the facts and the judgment, then the mock hearing). The timings, outcomes, stopping points and emergency exits are in the road map. All answer keys are printed under the exercises.

Lesson 1 · 52 min

Session 1 · A constitution nobody can print

Reading | Debate

You already know (The King Reigns, session 1 and session 5): the King is impartial and cannot give orders; Parliament makes the laws; Royal Assent is a formality. **Now:** where do these rules come from, if there is no written constitution?

Question: Can a country be a democracy without a written constitution?

> Parliament has "the right to make or unmake any law whatever; and, further, … no person or body is recognised by the law of England as having a right to override or set aside the legislation of Parliament."
> *A. V. Dicey, Introduction to the Study of the Law of the Constitution, 1885, chapter 1 (public domain)*

1. **Warm-up (7 min).** Students list where the "rules" of France are written (the Constitution of 1958). Then: where would you look for the rules of the UK? Answer: statutes, court decisions, conventions, works of authority.
2. **Reading Dicey (15 min).** Identify the two halves of the principle: positive (make or unmake any law) and negative (no one can override it). Why is this both a strength and a danger?
3. **Concept: convention (6 min).** A rule that is followed but not legally enforced, such as the monarch giving Royal Assent to every bill passed by Parliament. The last refusal was by Queen Anne in 1708.
4. **Mini-debate (14 min).** Motion: "This house believes the UK should adopt a written constitution." Two speakers per side, one minute each; then the floor: every other student asks a question or adds one argument.

> Model answer: strength and danger
>
> Strength: the system is flexible; Parliament can respond quickly to change, and the elected Commons has the last word. Danger: a government with a large majority could in theory pass any law, even one that removes rights, because no court can strike down an Act of Parliament. Critics call this an "elective dictatorship", a phrase used by Lord Hailsham in 1976.

Exercise 1.1 · Where are the rules?

Classify each item: **statute** (Act of Parliament), **court decision**, **convention** or **work of authority**. One item is not British: which one?

1. Magna Carta, 1297 version
2. The Bill of Rights 1689
3. The monarch always gives Royal Assent
4. The Prime Minister must command the confidence of the Commons
5. R (Miller) v The Prime Minister, 2019
6. Dicey, *Introduction to the Study of the Law of the Constitution*
7. The Constitution of 4 October 1958
8. The House of Lords (Hereditary Peers) Act 2026

> Answer key
>
> Statutes: 1, 2, 8. Court decision: 5. Conventions: 3, 4. Work of authority: 6. Not British: 7, the French Constitution, the only one printed in a single text.

Exercise 1.2 · The language of Dicey

Match each expression with its meaning: (1) to make or unmake a law; (2) to override; (3) to set aside; (4) to be recognised by the law; (5) an elective dictatorship.

(a) to treat a decision as having no effect; (b) to have a status accepted by the courts; (c) to pass or repeal a law; (d) an elected government so strong that nothing can stop it; (e) to use a higher authority to cancel a decision.

> Answer key
>
> 1 c · 2 e · 3 a · 4 b · 5 d.

Homework: 120 words. "The British constitution is a strength, not a weakness." Agree or disagree, with one example. Start your flashcards (five cards).

Lesson 2 · 52 min

Session 2 · Magna Carta, 1215: myth and law

Primary source | Mediation

You already know (The King Reigns, session 2 and session 3): the story of Runnymede, the rewriting of chapter 29 in today's English, its afterlife in the Fifth Amendment and in 1948. **Now:** we do not rewrite the clause again; we read it as a legal text, and we ask who turned it into a myth, and why.

Question: Is Magna Carta a founding text of democracy, or a deal between a king and his barons?

> "No freeman shall be taken or imprisoned, or be disseised of his freehold, or liberties, or free customs, or be outlawed, or exiled, or any other wise destroyed; nor will We not pass upon him, nor condemn him, but by lawful judgment of his peers, or by the law of the land. We will sell to no man, we will not deny or defer to any man either justice or right."
> *Magna Carta, 1297 version, chapter 29 (clauses 39 and 40 of 1215). Still in force. Source: legislation.gov.uk, 25 Edw 1 cc. 1-25*

> "Magna Charta is such a fellow, that he will have no sovereign."
> *Sir Edward Coke, speech in the House of Commons, 17 May 1628, during the debates on the Petition of Right (public domain)*

1. **Close reading.** Who is protected? ("freeman": a minority in 1215.) Who makes the promise? Underline every negative: what does the accumulation suggest?
2. **Myth versus history.** The charter was annulled by the Pope within weeks. It was reissued in 1216, 1217 and 1225. Its prestige comes later, in the 17th century, and in the American colonies. In 1628, Sir Edward Coke used it against Charles I: the charter, he said, "will have no sovereign".
3. **Mediation (C1 option).** In French, 80 words: explain to a classmate in history why this clause is still quoted today, and why historians are cautious.

> Key points

- The clause establishes due process: the king himself is under "the law of the land".
- It protected free men, not serfs or women; it was not democratic in the modern sense.
- Its power is symbolic: it is invoked in the US Fifth Amendment and in the Universal Declaration of Human Rights debates.

Exercise 2.1 · Close reading

1. How many negative words (no, not, nor) can you find in chapter 29?
2. Find the words that mean: (a) deprived of his land; (b) declared outside the protection of the law; (c) to delay.
3. Who is "We"? What is unusual about a king using this pronoun in a promise?
4. Which two guarantees are given: one for the person, one for justice?

> Answer key
>
> 1. Six: No, nor, not, nor, no, not. The accumulation shows how complete the protection is meant to be. 2. (a) disseised of his freehold; (b) outlawed; (c) defer. 3. The king himself (the royal "We"): the ruler binds himself by his own words. 4. No arrest or punishment without lawful judgment or the law of the land; justice cannot be sold, refused or delayed.

Exercise 2.2 · Myth or history?

Say whether each statement is **history** (true) or **myth** (false), and correct the myths.

1. Magna Carta gave the vote to the people of England.
2. The Pope declared the charter void a few weeks after Runnymede.
3. Clause 39 protected every person in England, including serfs.
4. The charter was reissued several times in the 13th century.
5. Lawyers in the 17th century used it against the king.
6. King John signed Magna Carta with a pen.

> Answer key
>
> 1. Myth: it said nothing about voting; Parliament did not yet exist. 2. History (Innocent III, August 1215). 3. Myth: "freeman" excluded serfs, the majority. 4. History: 1216, 1217, 1225 (and 1297). 5. History: Coke in 1628. 6. Myth: it was sealed, not signed (you saw this in The King Reigns, session 2).

Exercise 2.3 · Coke's sentence (B2, C1)

1. What figure of speech turns the charter into "a fellow"?
2. Who is the "sovereign" Coke has in mind in 1628?
3. C1: in two sentences, explain how this sentence turns a medieval deal into a principle.

> Answer key
>
> 1. Personification. 2. Charles I, who imprisoned subjects without trial and raised money without Parliament. 3. Coke presents the charter as a living authority above the king, not as a bargain of 1215: the law, not the ruler, has the last word. This reading, more than the original text, made Magna Carta a founding myth.

Homework: find one modern speech or article that quotes Magna Carta. What is it used to justify?

Lesson 3 · 52 min

Session 3 · 1689: Parliament takes control

Primary source | Analysis

You already know (The King Reigns, session 4): the spelling of the Bill of Rights, what the King can no longer do, the Black Rod ritual. **Now:** no spelling game. We ask how the text justifies itself, and why article 9 still protects MPs in 2026.

Question: How did a revolution without a revolution change who holds power?

> "Whereas the late King James the Second by the Assistance of diverse evill Councellors Judges and Ministers imployed by him did endeavour to subvert and extirpate the Protestant Religion and the Lawes and Liberties of this Kingdome …"
> *Bill of Rights 1689, preamble (original spelling). Source: legislation.gov.uk, 1 Will & Mar Sess 2 c 2*

> "That the pretended power of suspending of laws or the execution of laws by regall authority without consent of Parlyament is illegall." … "That the freedome of speech and debates or proceedings in Parlyament ought not to be impeached or questioned in any court or place out of Parlyament."
> *Bill of Rights 1689, article 1 and article 9 (original spelling). Source: legislation.gov.uk, 1 Will & Mar Sess 2 c 2*

1. **Context.** James II, a Catholic king, is replaced by William and Mary. They accept the Bill of Rights as a condition of the throne. The preamble blames "evill Councellors", not the institution of monarchy.
2. **Analysis.** Why does the text say "pretended" power? (The king never legally had it.) What does article 9 protect, and why does it still matter for MPs today?
3. **Link.** Article 9 was at the heart of the 2019 prorogation case (session 6).

> Model answer
>
> The word "pretended" rewrites history: Parliament claims it is restoring old rights, not making a revolution. This strategy gives the change legitimacy. Article 9 protects parliamentary privilege: an MP cannot be sued for what they say in the Commons. It makes Parliament a space of free debate that no court controls.

Exercise 3.1 · How the text justifies itself

1. In the preamble, who is blamed for the crisis: the monarchy, James II, or his advisers?
2. What do the verbs "subvert" and "extirpate" mean, and what image do they create?
3. Why is it clever to call the king's power "pretended" rather than "abolished"?

> Answer key
>
> 1. James II, helped by "evill Councellors Judges and Ministers": the institution itself is spared, so William and Mary can inherit it. 2. To overthrow; to pull up by the roots. The image is of a king destroying the nation's liberties at the root. 3. "Abolished" would admit that the power existed and that Parliament is innovating; "pretended" says it never existed, so Parliament is only restoring the law.

Exercise 3.2 · Article 9 today

Is the person protected by article 9? Answer yes or no and explain.

1. During a debate in the Commons, an MP accuses a company of hiding a safety report.

2. The same MP repeats the accusation, word for word, in a television interview the next morning.
3. A government asks a court to rule that a speech made in the Commons was illegal.

> Answer key
>
> 1. Yes: words spoken in proceedings in Parliament cannot be questioned in any court. 2. No: the interview is a "place out of Parlyament", so the ordinary law (for example on defamation) applies. 3. The court would refuse: proceedings in Parliament "ought not to be impeached or questioned in any court".

Exercise 3.3 · 1689 and 1789

Complete the comparison: who acted, what was the method, what was the result for the monarch?

> Answer key

	England, 1689	**France, 1789**
Who acted	Parliament (a Convention of Lords and Commons)	The Third Estate, then the National Assembly, and the people of Paris
Method	A negotiated change, presented as a restoration of old rights	A break with the past: a new Declaration of rights, then a new constitution
Monarch	A new king and queen, who accept limits as a condition of the throne	Louis XVI keeps his throne at first, then the monarchy is abolished in 1792
Same goal?	Both limit arbitrary royal power and give an assembly control of laws and taxes.	

Homework: compare 1689 with 1789 in France in 100 words: same goal, different method?

Lesson 4 · 52 min

Session 4 · The dignified Crown

Theory | Speaking

You already know (The King Reigns, session 5): Bagehot's two parts, summed up; the King reigns but does not rule; the Government writes the King's Speech. **Now:** Bagehot's own words, a harder sort in which some items belong to both columns, and a paradox to defend.

Question: If the King has no real power, what is he for?

> The constitution has "first, those which excite and preserve the reverence of the population, the dignified parts … and next, the efficient parts, those by which it, in fact, works and rules." The sovereign has "three rights: the right to be consulted, the right to encourage, the right to warn."
> *Walter Bagehot, The English Constitution, 1867, chapters 1 and 3 (public domain)*

1. **Sort.** Classify into dignified or efficient: the Coronation (Charles III, 6 May 2023), the King's Speech, Prime Minister's Questions, the weekly audience, Royal Assent, the Cabinet. In The King Reigns you sorted four simple items; here, justify every choice, and say which items belong to both columns.
2. **Discussion.** Is "dignified" a compliment or a criticism? Is a symbolic head of state useful in a divided country?

3. **Speaking task.** 2 minutes: "The monarchy is the most efficient part of the constitution precisely because it is dignified."

> Elements for the paradox
>
> Because the monarch is above party politics, the Crown can embody the nation in moments of crisis or mourning, while the elected government takes the blame for decisions. Its neutrality is a political resource. Counter-argument: it costs money, it is hereditary and so contradicts equality, and support among young people is lower than among older generations.

Exercise 4.1 · The harder sort

Dignified, efficient or both? Give one reason for each.

1. The Coronation, 6 May 2023
2. The King's Speech
3. Prime Minister's Questions
4. The weekly audience
5. Royal Assent
6. The Cabinet

> Answer key
>
> 1. Dignified: ceremony, reverence, no decision. 2. Both: the King reads it (dignified) but the Government writes it and sets out its bills (efficient). 3. Efficient: the Prime Minister is held to account by MPs. 4. Both: a private ritual (dignified) where the King can be consulted, encourage and warn (Bagehot's three rights). 5. Both: a formality since 1708 (dignified), but without it a bill does not become law (efficient in form). 6. Efficient: it takes the decisions of government.

Exercise 4.2 · Consulted, encourage or warn?

Which of the three rights is used in each situation?

1. The Prime Minister tells the King about a plan before it is announced.
2. The King says privately that a new apprenticeship scheme is an excellent idea.
3. The King asks whether a reform might divide the four nations, and suggests caution.

> Answer key
>
> 1. The right to be consulted. 2. The right to encourage. 3. The right to warn. All three are used in private: the audience is confidential.

Next lesson: mid-sequence assessment. Homework: watch extracts of the most recent King's Speech on the UK Parliament website: who wrote it? You know the answer from The King Reigns, so go further: list three bills it announces, and say which part of the ceremony is dignified and which is efficient.

Lesson 5 · 52 min

Mid-sequence assessment (after session 4)

52 minutes | Marked /20, coefficient 1

Purpose: check that students can read an authentic source and argue before the harder sessions on Brexit, the courts and the Union.

Part A · Reading an unseen source (/10)

> "The Sovereign has, under a constitutional monarchy such as ours, three rights: the right to be consulted, the right to encourage, the right to warn. And a king of great sense and sagacity would want no others."
> *Walter Bagehot, The English Constitution, 1867, chapter 3 (public domain)*

1. Explain in your own words the three rights of the Sovereign. (3 points)
2. What does "would want no others" suggest about Bagehot's view of royal power? (2 points)
3. Give one real modern example of each right, using the weekly audience and the King's Speech. (3 points)
4. Is Bagehot describing what the monarch can do, or what the monarch should do? Justify. (2 points)

Teacher's note: keeping Part A unseen. The first sentence of this extract was read in session 4 here and in session 5 of The King Reigns. For a class that knows it well, use the alternative unseen extract below, from the same chapter, with its own questions and key. Both versions are marked out of 10 with the same grid.

Part A, alternative unseen extract (/10)

> "Above all things our royalty is to be reverenced, and if you begin to poke about it you cannot reverence it. When there is a select committee on the Queen, the charm of royalty will be gone. Its mystery is its life. We must not let in daylight upon magic."
> *Walter Bagehot, The English Constitution, 1867, chapter "The Monarchy" (public domain, Project Gutenberg)*

1. According to Bagehot, what would destroy the "charm of royalty"? (3 points)
2. Explain the metaphor "We must not let in daylight upon magic." (2 points)
3. Give one modern example where the monarchy keeps its "mystery", and one where it is more open. (3 points)
4. Is this a description of the monarchy or advice to it? Justify. (2 points)

Part B · Short argument (/10)

150 to 180 words: "Magna Carta and the Bill of Rights limited the power of the King, not the power of the State." Agree or disagree, quoting at least one of the two texts.

> Answer key and marking guidance
>
> 1. Consulted: the government must inform the monarch. Encourage: support a policy. Warn: express concern privately. One point per right, explained without copying.
> 2. Royal power is limited and private; influence, not decision. A wise king accepts this.
> 3. Audience with the Prime Minister every week (consulted, encourage, warn in private); the King's Speech is written by the government, so the King does not choose its content.
> 4. Both: it is a description of practice in 1867 and a recommendation. Accept either if justified.
>
> Part B: 4 points for the argument (position, concession, example), 3 for use of the source, 3 for language. Expected argument: the texts moved power from the Crown to Parliament; Parliament itself, according to Dicey, can make any law, so the State was not limited.
>
> **Alternative extract.** 1. Close examination: "poke about it", a "select committee on the Queen", in other words publicity, inquiry and political criticism (one point per element). 2. Royalty works like magic: it needs half-light; if

> everything is exposed, the illusion disappears and so does the respect. 3. Mystery: the weekly audience is entirely private. Openness: the monarchy's public accounts, interviews or documentaries (accept any accurate example). 4. Both: Bagehot describes how royalty works ("its mystery is its life") and gives advice ("we must not"). Accept either if justified.

Marking grids for the teacher and the self-correction grid for students are in the grids section.

Lesson 6 · 52 min

Session 5 · Sovereignty and the people: the Brexit paradox

Data | Argument

You already know (The King Reigns, session 8): the 2016 figures nation by nation, the turnout, the coloured map.
Now: the figures are evidence for an argument about sovereignty, not a reading exercise.

Question: Who is sovereign when Parliament and the people disagree?

- 23 June 2016: the referendum on EU membership. Leave 51.9 %, Remain 48.1 %. England and Wales voted Leave; Scotland and Northern Ireland voted Remain.
- The referendum was legally advisory. Yet a majority of MPs had campaigned for Remain.
- Slogan of the Leave campaign: "Take back control."

1. **Analysis.** Control by whom, and from whom? Explain the paradox: a vote to restore the sovereignty of Parliament was a vote of the people that Parliament felt obliged to follow.
2. **The results by nation.** You coloured the map in The King Reigns; now interpret it: what do the results by nation reveal about the Union? Prepare the question of session 7.
3. **Writing (B2).** 180 words: "Referendums strengthen democracy." Discuss. Plan and introduction in class, the rest at home.

> Model plan
>
> For: a direct, clear answer on a major question; high turnout (72.2 %). Against: complex questions reduced to yes or no; a narrow majority imposes a decision on whole nations that voted differently; tension with representative democracy, where MPs are supposed to judge, not just obey (Edmund Burke, Speech to the Electors of Bristol, 1774).

Exercise 5.1 · Who is sovereign?

Complete with **Parliament** or **the people**.

1. In Dicey's theory, _____ is sovereign.
2. In 2016, _____ voted to leave the European Union.
3. The referendum was advisory, so in law _____ could have ignored it.
4. In practice, _____ felt it had to follow the vote of _____.
5. "Take back control" claimed to return power to _____ at Westminster.

> Answer key
>
> 1. Parliament. 2. the people. 3. Parliament. 4. Parliament; the people. 5. Parliament. The paradox: the people used their vote to give power back to an institution that then had to obey them.

Exercise 5.2 · Hedging (C1)

Rewrite each statement in a more cautious, academic way: It could be argued that … / This would seem to suggest … / … may well …

1. Referendums are bad for democracy.
2. The 2016 result shows that the UK is breaking up.
3. MPs betrayed their own opinions.

> Possible answers
>
> 1. It could be argued that referendums weaken representative democracy when the question is complex. 2. The results by nation would seem to suggest that the Union is under strain. 3. Many MPs may well have felt obliged to vote against their own judgment.

Homework: finish the 180 words, then read the Burke quotation on the sources page and summarise it in one sentence.

Lessons 7 and 8 · 2 × 52 min

Session 6 · Courts versus government: prorogation, 2019

Court judgment | Role play

New ground. The King Reigns did not study the courts. Link with what you know: the King acts on the advice of the Prime Minister (The King Reigns, session 1), and article 9 of the Bill of Rights (session 3 here).

Question: Can judges stop a Prime Minister?

> The decision to advise Her Majesty to prorogue Parliament "was unlawful because it had the effect of frustrating or preventing the ability of Parliament to carry out its constitutional functions without reasonable justification."
> *R (Miller) v The Prime Minister; Cherry v Advocate General for Scotland [2019] UKSC 41, 24 September 2019, the Court's conclusion*

Lesson 7 · The facts and the judgment

1. **Facts.** In August 2019, Boris Johnson advised the Queen to suspend Parliament for five weeks before the Brexit deadline. The Supreme Court, unanimously (11 judges), declared the prorogation void. Parliament returned the next day.
2. **Discussion.** Is this the courts protecting parliamentary sovereignty, or the courts entering politics? Link with Dicey (session 1) and article 9 (session 3).

Lesson 8 · The mock hearing

3. **Mock hearing (C1).** Three groups: counsel for the government, counsel for the claimants, the judges. Each counsel speaks 3 minutes; the judges deliver a reasoned ruling. Each member of a group delivers at least one argument or one reason.

> Arguments for each side
>
> **Government:** prorogation is a prerogative power and a political matter; judges have no legitimacy to decide it.
> **Claimants:** if the government can silence Parliament, Parliament is not sovereign; the courts only defend a principle

> the constitution already contains. **Ruling:** the Court said it was not deciding when Brexit should happen, only protecting Parliament's role.

Exercise 6.1 · The timeline (lesson 7)

Put the events in order.

a. The Supreme Court declares the prorogation void.
b. Boris Johnson advises the Queen to prorogue Parliament.
c. Parliament is prorogued.
d. The Commons sit again.
e. In London, the High Court says the question is not for the courts.
f. In Edinburgh, the Inner House of the Court of Session finds the prorogation unlawful.

> Answer key
>
> b (28 August 2019), e (6 September), c (night of 9 to 10 September), f (11 September), a (24 September), d (25 September). The two courts below disagreed: that is why the Supreme Court had to decide.

Exercise 6.2 · The language of the judgment (lesson 7)

Explain in simple English: (1) to prorogue; (2) unlawful; (3) frustrating or preventing; (4) constitutional functions; (5) without reasonable justification; (6) void.

> Answer key
>
> 1. To end a session of Parliament, so that it stops sitting until the next one. 2. Against the law. 3. Making it harder, or making it impossible. 4. The jobs Parliament must do: make laws and hold the government to account. 5. With no good reason that the government could show the Court. 6. Having no legal effect at all, as if it had never happened.

Exercise 6.3 · Conditionals and inversion for the ruling (lesson 8, C1)

Rewrite with an inversion, as a judge would.

1. If the Court had not intervened, Parliament would have stayed silent for five weeks.
2. A court had never before ruled on the advice given to the monarch to prorogue.
3. Parliament not only returned the next day, but it also resumed its work at once.

> Answer key
>
> 1. Had the Court not intervened, Parliament would have stayed silent for five weeks. 2. Never before had a court ruled on the advice given to the monarch to prorogue. 3. Not only did Parliament return the next day, but it also resumed its work at once.

Homework after lesson 7: prepare your part of the mock hearing (three sentences, one link to Dicey or to article 9).
Homework after lesson 8: 150 words: "The judges did their job." Agree or disagree.

Lesson 9 · 52 min

Session 7 · An unelected chamber and a disunited kingdom?

Current affairs | Debate

You already know (The King Reigns, session 6 and session 8): the stages of the Hereditary Peers Act 2026, devolution and the 2014 referendum. **Now:** not the path of the bill but its legitimacy; not the 2014 figures but the 2022 ruling and the clash of two ideas of sovereignty.

Question: Is the UK still one country with one Parliament?

The Lords

The House of Lords (Hereditary Peers) Act 2026 received Royal Assent on 18 March 2026. Since the end of the session on 29 April 2026, the House has been made up only of life peers and bishops (Lords Spiritual). Is an appointed chamber more legitimate than a hereditary one?

The Union

- Devolution, 1998-1999: Scottish Parliament, Welsh Assembly (now Senedd), Northern Ireland Assembly.
- Scottish independence referendum, 18 September 2014: No 55.3 %, Yes 44.7 %.
- November 2022: the UK Supreme Court rules that the Scottish Parliament cannot legislate for a new referendum without Westminster's consent.

> Without a change to the reserved matters, "the Scottish Parliament does not have the power to legislate for a referendum on Scottish independence."
> *Reference by the Lord Advocate of devolution issues [2022] UKSC 31, 23 November 2022, press summary of the unanimous judgment (short quotation, UK Supreme Court)*

1. **Reading.** Compare the "Take back control" logic of session 5 with the Scottish nationalist argument: same logic, opposite conclusion?
2. **Debate.** Motion: "Westminster should allow a second independence referendum."

> Key argument
>
> If sovereignty belongs to the people, as the Brexit vote suggested, then the Scottish people can claim the same right. But legally, sovereignty belongs to Parliament at Westminster, which is why the Supreme Court refused. The UK is therefore a union whose legal theory and political reality do not match.

Exercise 7.1 · For or against a second referendum?

Sort the arguments into **for** and **against** the motion.

1. Scotland voted Remain in 2016 and was taken out of the EU against its will.
2. The 2014 vote was presented as a once-in-a-generation decision.
3. The SNP, which supports independence, won the Scottish Parliament elections of 2016 and 2021.
4. The constitution is a reserved matter, decided at Westminster.
5. Another referendum would divide families and communities again.

> Answer key
>
> For: 1, 3. Against: 2, 4, 5. A C1 speaker answers the strongest argument of the other side first.

Exercise 7.2 · Elected, hereditary, appointed

Complete with **elected**, **hereditary** or **appointed**.

1. MPs are _____ by the voters of their constituency.
2. Before 2026, 92 members of the Lords sat because of a _____ title.
3. Life peers are _____ by the King on the advice of the Prime Minister.
4. Critics say an _____ chamber is more legitimate than an _____ one, but less than an _____ one.

> Answer key
>
> 1. elected. 2. hereditary. 3. appointed. 4. appointed; hereditary; elected.

Homework: prepare a 1-minute statement as a Scottish, Welsh, Northern Irish or English MP.

Lesson 10 · 52 min

Session 8 · Votes at 16: a bill in progress

Parliamentary briefing | Final preparation

You already know (The King Reigns, session 8): the GOV.UK summary of the bill and a first debate, for or against. **Now:** the official briefing, the other provisions of the bill, and a debate where every speaker must use a figure and answer the previous speaker.

Question: Should 16-year-olds vote in general elections?

- The Representation of the People Bill was introduced in the House of Commons on 12 February 2026.
- It passed its third reading in the Commons on 2 September 2026 by 411 votes to 102. In November 2026 it is at committee stage in the House of Lords.
- It would give about 1.7 million 16- and 17-year-olds the vote. They can already vote in devolved elections in Scotland and Wales.
- The Conservative Party and Reform UK oppose the change; most other parties support it.

1. **Reading.** Read the House of Commons Library briefing (link in Sources). Identify three provisions besides votes at 16.
2. **Debate.** As a class of 16- and 17-year-olds: are you ready? Arguments on maturity, taxation, civic education, the Scottish example. Every speaker uses one figure and answers the previous speaker.
3. **Briefing for the final task.** Choose your role and your format.

> Arguments
>
> **For:** consistency across the UK; 16-year-olds can work and pay tax; voting early creates a habit; Scottish experience since 2014-2015. **Against:** legal adulthood is 18 everywhere else; risk of influence by teachers or social media; low youth turnout. A C1 answer should weigh evidence, not just list it.

Exercise 8.1 · The facts of the bill

1. The bill was introduced in the Commons on _____.
2. Third reading in the Commons: _____ votes to _____.
3. About _____ young people would gain the vote.
4. In November 2026, the bill is at _____ stage in the _____.
5. Two parties opposed to the change: _____ and _____.

> Answer key
>
> 1. 12 February 2026. 2. 411; 102. 3. 1.7 million. 4. committee; House of Lords. 5. the Conservative Party; Reform UK. Check the stage on the UK Parliament website before the lesson: it may have moved on.

Exercise 8.2 · Weighing evidence (C1)

Turn this list into one weighed sentence, using *carries more weight than*, *is outweighed by* or *admittedly … yet …*: "16-year-olds pay tax. Youth turnout is low."

> Possible answers
>
> Admittedly, youth turnout is low; yet the fact that many 16-year-olds already work and pay tax carries more weight, since there should be no taxation without representation. Or: The tax argument is outweighed, some would say, by the risk of very low turnout, which could weaken the mandate of those elected.

This bill is still in progress: check its stage on the UK Parliament website before the lesson.

Homework: choose your final task and write its plan. Finish your flashcard pack.

Language for argument

Building your vocabulary: constitutional debate

- **sovereignty**: supreme authority; **parliamentary sovereignty**
- **convention**: unwritten rule; **Royal Assent**
- **prerogative powers**: powers exercised by ministers in the name of the Crown
- **accountability**: having to answer for one's decisions
- **legitimacy**, **mandate**, **devolution**, **to prorogue**, **to override**, **a bill** / **an Act**

Already met in The King Reigns: Royal Assent, devolution, a bill / an Act, consent, to appoint, turnout. Revise them on your flashcards; the new words are the others.

Structures B2 to C1

- Conceding then countering: *Admittedly, …; nevertheless, … · While it is true that …, it does not follow that …*
- Hedging: *It could be argued that … · This would seem to suggest …*
- Inversion for emphasis (C1): *Never before had a court … · Not only did Parliament …, but it also …*
- Third conditional and mixed conditional: *Had the Court not intervened, Parliament would still be silent.*
- Passive and impersonal forms: *The prorogation was declared void.*

Exercise L.1 · The right word

Complete with: sovereignty, convention, prerogative, accountability, legitimacy, mandate, to prorogue, to override.

1. Prime Minister's Questions is a weekly exercise in _____.
2. A government elected on a clear manifesto claims a _____ for its reforms.
3. Royal Assent is never refused: it is a _____, not a law.
4. In 2019, the Prime Minister used a _____ power _____ Parliament.
5. According to Dicey, no court can _____ an Act of Parliament.

6. An appointed chamber has less democratic _____ than an elected one.
7. For Brexit supporters, leaving the EU restored national _____.

> Answer key
>
> 1. accountability. 2. mandate. 3. convention. 4. prerogative; to prorogue. 5. override. 6. legitimacy. 7. sovereignty.

Exercise L.2 · Concede, then counter

Join the two ideas with the structure given.

1. (Admittedly …; nevertheless …) The monarchy is expensive. / It unites the nation in times of crisis.
2. (While it is true that …, it does not follow that …) The UK has no written constitution. / Its citizens have no rights.
3. (Not only … but also …, with inversion) The Court declared the prorogation void. / It said Parliament had never been prorogued.

> Answer key
>
> 1. Admittedly, the monarchy is expensive; nevertheless, it unites the nation in times of crisis. 2. While it is true that the UK has no written constitution, it does not follow that its citizens have no rights. 3. Not only did the Court declare the prorogation void, but it also said that Parliament had never been prorogued.

My bristol flashcards · how to use them

From The King Reigns. If you made a pack in The King Reigns, keep it: those cards go straight into box 3 after one check. Make new cards only for the new words, sources and structures below.

Principle. Each student makes their own cards by hand, on bristol cards. Writing the word is already a way of learning it. The pack stays in the bag, so students can revise anywhere, with no screen. There is no ready-made deck: this page gives the method, a few model cards and a blank template.

Materials

A7 bristol cards (74 × 105 mm), about 25 per student, or A6 bristols cut in half. Felt-tip pens in four colours. An elastic band or an envelope for the pack. A small cardboard box with three compartments for practice (a shoe box with two dividers is enough). You can also print the blank template and cut it out.

What goes on a card

	What to write
Front	One English word, phrase, date or structure, in the colour of its category.
Back	A short meaning in English (a French translation only if you need it) and one example sentence of your own, linked to Who Rules Britain?.
Corner	The category and the session where you met the item.
Check	Can I give the meaning and an example without turning the card over?

Colour code

Category	Pen colour
Vocabulary	green
Structures and grammar	red
Primary sources and quotations	blue
Dates and figures	purple

When to make the cards

When	Cards to make
End of lessons 1, 2, 3, 6, 7 and 9	Four or five cards: the new words and the key quotation of the session (homework).
Lesson 4, before the mid-sequence assessment	Revise sessions 1 to 4 with your cards; add one card for each primary source.
Lesson 11, revision workshop	Finish the pack (20 cards or more), then practise in pairs with three boxes.
Before the written test and the final task	Ten minutes a day with box 1 and box 2.

Practice in pairs, with three boxes

Student A shows the front; student B gives the meaning and a sentence. A card that is right moves on one box. A card that is wrong goes back to box 1. Target before the final task: 15 cards in box 3.

Model cards

What to put on cards

Choose the items you still hesitate on. One item per card. Do not copy the whole list.

- **Vocabulary:** sovereignty, convention, prerogative powers, accountability, legitimacy, mandate, devolution, to prorogue, to override, to set aside, due process, parliamentary privilege, reserved matter, life peer, advisory referendum
- **Primary sources:** Magna Carta ch. 29 (1297); Coke 1628; Bill of Rights 1689, preamble, articles 1 and 9; Burke 1774; Bagehot 1867; Dicey 1885; Miller 2019; the 2022 Scottish reference
- **Structures:** Admittedly …; nevertheless …; While it is true that …, it does not follow that …; It could be argued that …; Never before had …; Not only did …, but …; Had … not …, … would …
- **Dates and figures:** 1215, 1628, 1689, 1708, 1885, 2014 (55.3 %), 2016 (51.9 %, turnout 72.2 %), 24 September 2019, November 2022, 18 March 2026, 411 to 102

Grid · my pack of cards /10

Criterion	Points
20 cards or more, with the colour code respected	/ 2
Clear handwriting, correct spelling on the front and the back	/ 3
A precise example of your own on the back (not only a translation)	/ 3

Check: the teacher draws five cards and the student answers (four right answers or more = 2 points)	/ 2

Lessons 12 and 13 · 2 × 52 min, or one 2-hour exam slot

Summative assessment (end of sequence)

The summative assessment has two parts, marked separately, so that both written and oral skills are assessed.

Part	Format	Weight
1. Written test, in class	Reading of two unseen sources + argumentative essay, 2 hours (or lessons 12 and 13)	/20, coefficient 2
2. Final task	Speech, op-ed or mock ruling (see below), lesson 14	/20, coefficient 2

Part 1 · Written test (2 hours)

Document A: extract from the Supreme Court judgment of 24 September 2019 (the Court's conclusion, about 150 words). Document B: the summary of the Representation of the People Bill on GOV.UK ("Votes at 16" policy summary, first two paragraphs).

Documents A and B are not reproduced here. Print them on the day from the UK Supreme Court page (judgment, final paragraphs) and from GOV.UK. Document A is "unseen" only in part: students know the conclusion quoted in session 6, so choose the paragraphs that come just before it.

1. Comprehension, Document A (/5): what was the government's decision, why did the Court find it unlawful, and what principle did it protect?
2. Comprehension, Document B (/5): list the main changes proposed and explain the reason the government gives.
3. Mediation in French (/4): in 100 words, explain to your French parents why judges in the UK were able to cancel a decision of the Prime Minister.
4. Essay (/6), 250 to 300 words: "In the United Kingdom, the people are sovereign in theory but Parliament is sovereign in practice." Discuss, using at least two examples from the sequence.

In two lessons: questions 1 to 3 in lesson 12, the essay in lesson 13.

> Answer key
>
> 1. The Prime Minister advised the Queen to prorogue Parliament for five weeks; the Court found it frustrated Parliament's ability to carry out its functions without reasonable justification; it protected parliamentary sovereignty and accountability of the government.
> 2. Voting age lowered to 16 for all UK elections; registration from 14; data protection for young people. Reason: consistency with Scotland and Wales and participation of 1.7 million young people.
> 3. Mediation is assessed on accuracy, selection of information and adaptation to the reader; no word-for-word translation.
> 4. Expected ideas: Dicey's doctrine; referendums as advisory (Brexit); the paradox of "take back control"; the Scottish case and the 2022 ruling; votes at 16 decided by Parliament, not by referendum.

Lesson 14 · 52 min

Summative part 2 · Final task: "Who rules Britain?"

A step up from The King Reigns. There, the speech lasted 3 minutes and the op-ed 250 to 300 words on Magna Carta. Here, the speech is followed by 2 minutes of questions, the op-ed is longer and on a new question, and a third, C1 option is added.

Students choose one of three tasks. All three require using at least **three primary sources** from the sequence and answering **one objection**.

1. **Speech in the Commons (4 minutes + 2 minutes of questions).** You are a newly elected MP. Speak for or against the Representation of the People Bill, or for or against a written constitution.
2. **Op-ed (350 to 400 words).** For a British newspaper: "Britain needs a written constitution." Argue for or against.
3. **Mock Supreme Court ruling (C1, in pairs).** Write and present a short judgment (300 words) on an invented case: a government suspends Parliament for three months during a national emergency.

In lesson 14, op-eds are handed in at the start; speeches and rulings are delivered (about seven per lesson); op-ed writers ask the questions. With a larger group, the remaining speeches open the next lessons, two per lesson.

Assessment grid

Criterion	Points	Mark
Task achievement: a clear position answering the question	/4	_____
Use of sources: three primary sources, accurately quoted and explained	/4	_____
Argument: concession, rebuttal, nuanced conclusion	/4	_____
Language range: constitutional vocabulary and complex structures	/4	_____
Accuracy and fluency (or interaction for the speech)	/4	_____

Total: 0 / 20

On paper: Total _____ / 20. Indicative level: 10 to 13 = B1+, 14 to 16 = B2, 17 to 20 = towards C1.

Marking grids for the teacher

Mid-sequence assessment · Part A, reading (/10)

Criterion	Insufficient	Developing (B1)	Secure (B2)	Advanced (C1)
Understanding of the three rights (/3)	Rights copied or confused (0-1)	Two rights explained (1.5-2)	Three rights explained in own words (2.5)	Precise reformulation, nuance on private influence (3)
Interpretation of "would want no others" (/2)	No interpretation (0)	Literal meaning only (0.5-1)	Limits of royal power identified (1.5)	Link to wisdom and legitimacy of restraint (2)
Modern examples (/3)	No example (0-1)	One correct example (1.5)	Two or three examples correctly linked (2-2.5)	Accurate examples with explanation of the government's role (3)
Description or prescription (/2)	No justification (0)	Position without evidence (0.5-1)	Justified position (1.5)	Shows it is both, with textual evidence (2)

For the alternative extract, read the rows as: what destroys the charm (/3), the metaphor (/2), modern examples (/3), description or advice (/2).

Mid-sequence assessment · Part B, short argument (/10)

Criterion	Insufficient	Developing (B1)	Secure (B2)	Advanced (C1)
Argument (/4)	No clear position (0-1)	Position, one argument (1.5-2)	Position, two arguments, one concession (3)	Nuanced thesis distinguishing Crown, Parliament and State (4)
Use of sources (/3)	No reference (0)	Vague reference (1)	One accurate quotation explained (2)	Two texts quoted and compared (3)
Language (/3)	Frequent errors block meaning (0-1)	Simple, mostly correct (1.5)	Varied linkers and vocabulary (2-2.5)	Complex structures, precise terms, few errors (3)

Summative written test (/20)

Criterion	Insufficient	Developing (B1)	Secure (B2)	Advanced (C1)
Comprehension A (/5)	Facts wrong or missing (0-1)	Decision understood (2)	Decision and reason explained (3-4)	Principle identified and linked to sovereignty (5)
Comprehension B (/5)	Fewer than two changes (0-1)	Two changes listed (2)	Three changes and the reason (3-4)	Complete and precise, with figures (5)
Mediation in French (/4)	Translation or misunderstanding (0-1)	Main idea given (1.5-2)	Information selected for the reader (3)	Clear, adapted, concise explanation (4)
Essay (/6)	No structure, no example (0-1.5)	Plan visible, one example (2-3)	Two examples, concession, conclusion (4-5)	Nuanced discussion of theory v. practice, precise language (6)

Final task: speech, op-ed or mock ruling (/20)

Criterion	Insufficient	Developing (B1)	Secure (B2)	Advanced (C1)
Task achievement (/4)	Off topic (0-1)	Position stated (2)	Clear position sustained (3)	Persuasive and adapted to audience and genre (4)
Use of sources (/4)	None (0-1)	One source mentioned (2)	Three sources quoted accurately (3)	Sources used as evidence and discussed critically (4)
Argument (/4)	List of ideas (0-1)	Two arguments (2)	Concession and rebuttal (3)	Anticipates objections; nuanced conclusion (4)
Language range (/4)	Basic (0-1)	Some topic vocabulary (2)	Constitutional vocabulary and complex structures (3)	Wide, precise, idiomatic range (4)
Accuracy, fluency or interaction (/4)	Errors block meaning (0-1)	Understandable with effort (2)	Fluent, few errors (3)	Natural, reacts to questions without notes (4)

Use the descriptors to place each criterion, then choose the mark inside the band.

Self-correction grids for students

Mid-sequence assessment

Before I hand in, I check that…	Yes	Partly	No
I explained the three rights in my own words, without copying the text.	☐	☐	☐
I gave a modern example for each right.	☐	☐	☐
My argument has a clear position in the first sentence.	☐	☐	☐
I quoted Magna Carta or the Bill of Rights correctly, with quotation marks.	☐	☐	☐
I used at least one concession (Admittedly…, nevertheless…).	☐	☐	☐
I checked verbs (tense, -s at the third person) and spelling.	☐	☐	☐

My main strength: _____ · What I must improve next time: _____

Summative written test

Before I hand in, I check that…	Yes	Partly	No
I answered every question about Document A and Document B.	☐	☐	☐
My mediation is in French, adapted to my parents, and is not a translation.	☐	☐	☐
My essay has an introduction with the question, two parts and a conclusion.	☐	☐	☐
I used two examples from the sequence (Brexit, 2019 ruling, Scotland, votes at 16).	☐	☐	☐
I used vocabulary such as sovereignty, Parliament, mandate, accountability.	☐	☐	☐
I wrote between 250 and 300 words for the essay.	☐	☐	☐

My main strength: _____ · What I must improve next time: _____

Final task

Before I hand in, I check that…	Yes	Partly	No
I chose one format and respected its length or time.	☐	☐	☐
I used three primary sources from the sequence.	☐	☐	☐
I answered one objection.	☐	☐	☐
I used at least two complex structures (inversion, conditional, passive).	☐	☐	☐
For the speech: I rehearsed and can speak without reading.	☐	☐	☐
For the op-ed or ruling: I reread for accuracy and register.	☐	☐	☐

My main strength: _____ · What I must improve next time: _____

Sources

- Magna Carta (1297): legislation.gov.uk, chapter 29
- Bill of Rights 1689 (preamble, articles 1 and 9): legislation.gov.uk

- A. V. Dicey, Introduction to the Study of the Law of the Constitution (1885), and Walter Bagehot, The English Constitution (1867): public domain, available on Project Gutenberg (Bagehot).
- Sir Edward Coke, speech in the House of Commons, 17 May 1628: "Magna Charta is such a fellow, that he will have no sovereign" (public domain; recorded in the parliamentary debates of 1628).
- Edmund Burke, Speech to the Electors of Bristol (1774): "Your representative owes you, not his industry only, but his judgment; and he betrays, instead of serving you, if he sacrifices it to your opinion."
- Lord Hailsham, "elective dictatorship", Richard Dimbleby Lecture, 1976 (phrase quoted only).
- R (Miller) v The Prime Minister [2019] UKSC 41: UK Supreme Court
- Reference by the Lord Advocate of devolution issues [2022] UKSC 31: UK Supreme Court (short quotation from the press summary)
- House of Lords (Hereditary Peers) Act 2026 and House of Commons Library, Peerages and membership of the House of Lords
- House of Commons Library, Representation of the People Bill: progress of the bill
- GOV.UK, Votes at 16 policy summary
- Electoral Commission, briefings on the bill

Facts on current bills checked on 11 November 2026. Check the stage of the Representation of the People Bill before teaching session 8.

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